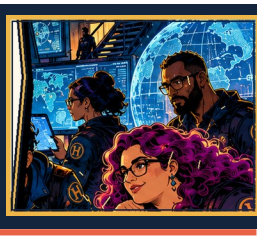
PLAYTESTING + LOGISTICS CHECKLIST

Practical guidance for one facilitator and many teams.



PLANNING SCENARIO 50 attendees • 10 teams • 1 facilitator • chairs only

CHOOSE A FORMAT THAT MATCHES THE REAL ROOM

Team packets reduce traffic and facilitator bottlenecks. Rotating stations can make sense when movement supports the objective and you have space and staffing to manage it.

PACKETS

Prepack one numbered kit per team; include spares.

NO TABLES

Use rigid folders or lap boards and large shared pieces.

SELF-CHECKS

Put answer validation, hints, and time-up recovery inside each kit.

PACING

Use visible time cues, optional stretch tasks, and one shared ending.

BACKUPS

Prepare paper verification, spare materials, and fast-reset instructions.

ACCESS

Use readable text, non-color-only cues, and flexible team roles.

PROTECT COGNITIVE CAPACITY

Make the decision difficult, not the directions. State one clear goal, chunk materials by stage, use consistent visual cues, and watch whether novices struggle with the rules rather than the intended decision.

KIT INVENTORY (ADAPT TO YOUR PUZZLE)

- ☐ Mission and one-page visual directions
- ☐ Chapter pieces and any reference criteria
- ☐ Writing surface, pencil, and answer/rationale checks
- ☐ Progressive hint strips and time-up recovery
- ☐ Finale pieces, paper fallback, reset diagram

RUN A REAL PLAYTEST / NOT JUST A SOLUTION CHECK

Observe fresh players using the actual room, time limit, packet, and devices. Record what happened, why it happened, and whether a revision worked.

BEFORE THE GAME

- ☐ Confirm the target decision and what counts as success.
- ☐ Solve the puzzle using only the information participants will receive.
- ☐ Check competing answers, ambiguous clues, dead ends, and shortcuts.
- ☐ Test fonts, contrast, reading level, manipulation, and non-phone options.
- ☐ Time reading, assembling, deciding, checking, and resetting separately.

DURING THE PLAYTEST

- ☐ Observe silently before intervening; record the exact point of confusion.
- ☐ Note whether everyone can meaningfully participate or one player dominates.
- ☐ Try self-checks and staged hints without relying on the facilitator.
- ☐ Give a three-minute and one-minute warning; test the shared time-up reveal.

AFTER THE PLAYTEST

- ☐ Ask: “What did you think the goal was? Which clue changed your decision?”
- ☐ Separate challenge difficulty from confusing instructions or missing data.
- ☐ Revise, then test again with somebody new.
- ☐ Try a comparable scenario to test learning beyond team completion.

PLAYTEST OBSERVATION + REVISION LOG

WHAT HAPPENED?	Note the exact clue, behavior, or moment: _____
WHY?	Unclear instructions, missing data, unintended shortcut, access, or other: _____
WHAT WILL CHANGE?	Planned revision and owner: _____
DID IT WORK?	Retest with a new solver; result: _____

DRY RUN **Distribution • Access • Sightlines • Timer • Ending • Reset • Tech fallback**

AI ART ATTRIBUTION Selected character artwork was generated with OpenAI image-generation tools and adapted for this resource. AI-assisted text drafting was reviewed and edited by the author.